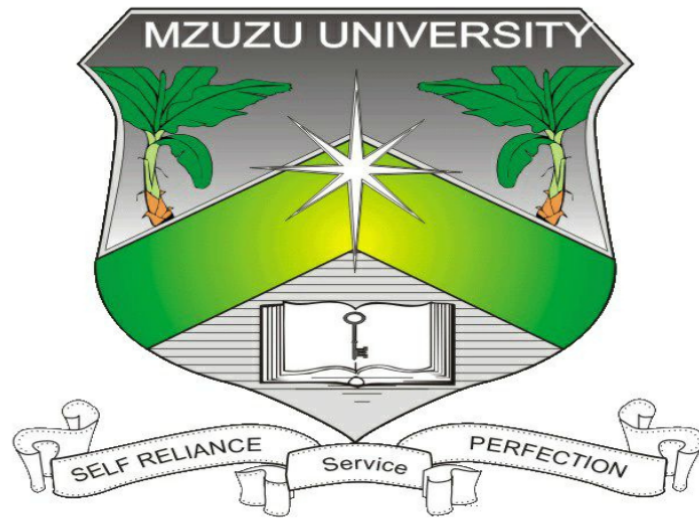




Faculty of Health Sciences

Department of Optometry

Department Procedure Manual 2023

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the Optometry Department at Mzuzu University. Our commitment lies in delivering exceptional educational and training experiences in eye care. This procedural handbook is crafted to be an indispensable guide for both our academic and non-academic staff. Its purpose is to streamline departmental functions, ensuring all processes are carried out with efficiency and effectiveness, thereby upholding our high standards of educational excellence.

1.1 PURPOSE

The aim of this manual is to furnish our staff with a comprehensive and clear set of guidelines, facilitating the performance of their roles with both ease and accuracy. Recognizing the importance of structured and well-defined procedures, this manual is integral to our mission of providing a superior quality of education in optometry. Adherence to these procedures is crucial in ensuring that our students are afforded the finest education and practical training in the field.

1.2 Objectives:

- To provide a detailed, step-by-step guide for all critical departmental operations, encompassing administrative tasks, semester activities, and subcommittee functions.
- To ensure uniformity in departmental processes, thus maintaining consistent, high-quality outcomes and fostering organizational stability.
- To improve departmental communication, clarifying roles and responsibilities, minimizing errors, and promoting collaboration.

In sum, this manual is a crucial tool for all staff in the Optometry Department, ensuring optimal education and departmental efficacy.

2.0 Semester Activities

2.1 Procedure 1: Request for funds

1. Obtain the form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill in your details and sign the form.
3. Include item descriptions, total amount, and funding account.
4. Attach a signed subsistence claims form.
5. Submit to the departmental secretary for HOD's signature.
6. The HOD reviews and, if satisfactory, signs the form.
7. The form is forwarded to the Faculty Office for the Dean's signature.

8. Next, it goes to the Finance Office for processing.
9. The DOF's secretary sends the form for fund availability verification.
10. UR reviews and approves the form.
11. The Vice Chancellor provides approval.
12. DOF gives the final approval.
13. The Voucher Office prepares the voucher.
14. The Financial Accountant gives the final voucher approvals.
15. Funds are remitted to the applicant's account or issued as a check.
16. For status inquiries, contact the Optometry or DOF's secretary.

2.2 Procedure 2: Request from Department Petty Cash

1. Obtain form DOPT FF02 from the secretary.
2. Fill in your details and sign the form.
3. Include item descriptions and total amount.
4. Submit to the secretary for finance sub-committee approval.
5. The form is then approved by the HOD.
6. The secretary disburses the funds.
7. Note: Requests must be made five days in advance.

2.3 Procedure 3: Request for Procurement

1. Begin by following steps 1 to 10 of Procedure 1, using the Request for Funds for Procurement (RFF Procurement) form.
2. Forward the completed form to the Procurement Department.
3. Issue a request for bids to at least three vendors.
4. Procurement evaluates the bids and presents them to the University Inventory Procurement and Disposal Committee (IPDC).
5. Upon IPDC's approval, Procurement issues a Local Purchase Order (LPO) and notifies the selected vendor to supply the goods.
6. The items are received and verified by the Procurement Office at the stores.
7. The requesting department then conducts its verification of the received items.
8. The verified items are released to the department inventory committee for documentation, utilizing a completed and signed requisition form.
9. Procurement prepares a new RFF for payment of the items and submits it to the Finance Department.
10. The payment process follows steps 7 to 13 of Procedure 1.
11. Funds are subsequently released to the vendor.

12. If the procurement is funded by the HSE account, the department must complete a procurement tracking form.

2.4 Procedure 4: Use of the Department Library

1. The department library is primarily for accessing and borrowing books.
2. To borrow books, request the library key from the departmental secretary.
3. Browse the library collection and select the desired books.
4. Register the borrowed books with the student library coordinator before taking them out.
5. Books that are the only copy available are not to be taken out of the library.
6. Return borrowed books promptly.
7. Staff members are advised to primarily utilize the main university library. Department library resources should be accessed when specific materials are not available in the main library.

2.5 Procedure 5: Request for equipment

1. Acquire the equipment requisition form Rf03 from the departmental secretary.
2. Complete the form with your name as the requesting officer and provide your signature.
3. Clearly describe the required equipment, its intended purpose, and the needed date.
4. Submit the signed form to the departmental secretary for review and approval by the Inventory sub-committee.
5. Following the sub-committee's approval, the form is advanced to the Head of Department (HOD) for final approval.
6. Once approved, the equipment is released to the requesting officer through the secretary.
7. Upon completion of use, return the equipment to the secretary.
8. The inventory committee then verifies and documents the returned equipment in the departmental records.

2.6 Procedure 6: Outreach

1. The outreach coordinator submits a formal request for outreach, including the meeting minutes where the decision was made, to the departmental secretary.

2. The minutes should detail the outreach venue, student groupings, class attending, budget, and confirm preliminary discussions with the outreach host and local optometrist.
3. The HOD reviews and approves the outreach plan.
4. The coordinator proceeds with fund and procurement requests as per Procedures 1, 2, and 3.
5. Five days prior to the trip, the coordinator requests necessary equipment using Procedure 5.
6. Finalize arrangements with the relevant stakeholders.
7. The committee collects the equipment a day before the trip.
8. Ensure the optometrist or their representative reaches the outreach venue as planned.
9. After the outreach, the equipment is returned and signed back in by the inventory committee.
10. The coordinator submits a detailed report of the outreach within five days of its conclusion.

2.7 Procedure 7: Industrial Visit Program

1. Lecturers planning an industrial visit should follow the same steps outlined in Procedure 6 for outreach.
2. However, for industrial visits, step 10 of Procedure 6 (submitting a post-visit report) is not required.

2.8 Procedure 8: Application Holiday

1. Obtain the leave application form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill in your name as the requesting officer and sign the form.
3. Specify the travel dates and arrangements to cover your assignments during the leave period.
4. Request a meeting with the Head of Department (HOD) to discuss the application.
5. The HOD reviews the form and, if there are no issues, signs it.
6. The form is then reviewed and approved by the University Registrar (UR).
7. In some cases, the approval of the faculty may suffice for the leave to commence.
8. For status inquiries regarding the leave application, contact the Optometry department's secretary.

2.9 Procedure 9: Application for promotion

1. Obtain the promotion criteria from the faculty upon announcement of promotion opportunities.
2. Ensure you meet the eligibility criteria for promotion.
3. Obtain the application form from the departmental secretary and fill in your details.
4. Attach documents demonstrating fulfillment of the criteria requirements.
5. Arrange a meeting with the HOD to discuss the application, using previous Performance Management System (PMS) records and attached evidence.
6. The HOD reviews the application and, if satisfactory, signs it.
7. The application is then forwarded to the Faculty Office for the Dean's review and signature.
8. The Human Resources Office sends the application to the Senior Academic Staff Promotion Committee for consideration.
9. The application is subsequently reviewed and approved by the UR and the Vice Chancellor.
10. The Human Resources Office communicates the final decision and, if successful, announces the promotion to the university community.

2.10 Procedure 10: Application for Contract renewal

1. Obtain the contract renewal form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill in your name as the requesting officer and provide your signature on the form.
3. Include details such as the expiration date of the current contract, achievements during the tenure of the existing contract, and the proposed dates for the new contract.
4. Request a meeting with the Head of Department (HOD) to discuss the renewal application.
5. The HOD reviews the application and, if there are no issues, signs it.
6. The application is then submitted to the Faculty Office for the Dean's review and signature.
7. The Human Resources (HR) Office refers the application to the University Registrar (UR), who reviews and recommends it to the Senior Academic Staff Promotion Committee.
8. The Vice Chancellor provides final approval on the application.
9. The UR officially communicates the approval of the contract renewal.
10. It is advisable to initiate the renewal process at least four months before the current contract's expiration.

2.11 Procedure 11: Official communication

- Official communications to the Head of Department (HOD) should be made via memos addressed directly to the HOD.
- Documents, requests, and reports can also be sent via email to hodoptometry@mzuni.ac.mw. For urgent matters requiring immediate response, use the academic staff WhatsApp forum.
- The WhatsApp forum is not for direct messages to other staff members or the HOD.
- Meeting minutes, announcements, and departmental updates are to be disseminated to academic staff via their Mzuni email addresses ending with @mzuni.ac.mw.

2.12 Procedure 12: Use of Optometry Vehicle

1. Submit vehicle usage requests to the Assistant Registrar Administration.
2. The request is reviewed by the HOD for consideration.
3. It is then forwarded to the inventory committee.
4. Upon favorable recommendation from the inventory committee, the HOD approves the request.
5. The HOD communicates approval to the Assistant Registrar Administration, who authorizes the transport office to release the vehicle.

2.13 Procedure 13: Request for transport

1. Obtain a transport booking form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill out the form with your name as the requesting officer and sign it.
3. Include details of the journey, number of passengers, and departure time.
4. Submit the form to the departmental secretary for the HOD's approval.
5. The HOD reviews and signs the form, requesting clarification if necessary.
6. Post-HOD approval, the form is sent to the AR admin for final approval.
7. Approval is contingent upon the RFF being approved.
8. The secretary then processes a fuel request as per Procedure 14.
9. Transport requests must be accompanied by an RFF covering expenses for officers and drivers, including allowances.
10. If the trip is project-sponsored, indicate the funding source on the form.

2.14 Procedure 14: Request for Fuel

1. The secretary obtains a fuel request form from the transport office.
2. The form specifies the assigned driver, fuel quantity, and departure time.

3. The HOD reviews and signs the form.
4. The form is submitted to the finance clerk for fuel disbursement.
5. Fuel allocation is either uploaded onto a fuel card or transferred to the relevant accounts.
6. Post-trip, fuel receipts are to be returned to the finance clerk.

2.15 Procedure 15: Request for Financial Help to Attend Conference

1. Obtain a conference financial assistance form from the departmental secretary.
2. Complete the form with your name as the requesting officer and sign it.
3. Include conference details and funding requirements.
4. Schedule a meeting with the HOD to discuss the request.
5. The HOD reviews and, if no issues are found, signs the form.
6. The form is then forwarded to the Faculty Office for the Dean's review and signature.
7. It's subsequently sent to the Finance Office for processing.
8. The DOF's secretary sends the form to the Management Accountant to verify fund availability.
9. Upon confirmation of funds, the UR reviews and approves the form.
10. The Vice Chancellor then provides final approval.
11. The DOF issues the final approval.
12. The Voucher Office prepares the financial voucher.
13. The Financial Accountant finalizes the voucher approvals.
14. For international conferences, a forex request is processed along with the voucher.

2.16 Procedure 16: Request for staff training

1. Obtain the Staff Development Committee (SDC) application form from the departmental secretary.
2. In case of simultaneous promotion applications, acquire the necessary promotion application form.
3. Complete the form with your name as the requesting officer and sign it.
4. Attach supporting documents, such as the offer letter and evidence of sponsorship, if applicable.
5. Schedule a meeting with the Head of Department (HOD) to discuss the application.
6. The HOD reviews and signs the form if satisfactory.
7. The signed form is then forwarded to the Faculty Office for the Dean's review and signature.

8. The Human Resource Office submits the form to the SDC for consideration at the next committee meeting.
9. The Assistant Registrar of Human Resources (ARHR) compiles and submits the meeting minutes for the Vice Chancellor's approval through the UR.
10. Post-approval, the ARHR provides feedback and further instructions.

2.17 Procedure 17: Request for Printing

1. Submit a printing request to the departmental secretary.
2. Indicate the number of copies, purpose, and required timeline.
3. Upon collection, register the details in the printing request logbook and sign for receipt.

2.18 Procedure 18: Request for emergency advance

1. Obtain an emergency advance request form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill out the form with your name as the requesting officer and provide your signature.
3. Specify the total amount requested and the proposed repayment duration.
4. The filled form is taken to the voucher office to check for any pending advances and to approve the repayment duration based on net salary.
5. Submit the form to the departmental secretary for the HOD's signature.
6. The HOD reviews the form and signs it if no issues arise.
7. The completed form is forwarded to the Finance Office for processing.
8. The DOF's secretary sends the form for fund availability verification.
9. If funds are available, the UR reviews and approves the form.
10. The DOF gives the final approval.
11. The Voucher Office prepares the voucher based on the approved form.
12. The Financial Accountant finalizes the voucher approvals.
13. Funds are then either transferred to the staff member's account or issued as a check.
14. For any inquiries about the status of the request, contact the secretary for Optometry or the DOF's secretary.

2.19 Procedure 19: Request for Part Time allowances

1. Part-time officers should obtain the relevant fund request form from the departmental secretary.
2. Complete the form with your name as the requesting officer and sign it.

3. Detail the courses taught, the number of hours claimed, and the total amount. Attach a duly signed subsistence claims form to the request for funds (RFF).
4. Submit the form to the departmental secretary for the Head of Department's (HOD) signature.
5. The HOD reviews the details, confirms the hours and amount, and signs the form if there are no discrepancies.
6. The form is then forwarded to the Faculty Office for review and signature by the Dean.
7. Alongside the RFF, the completed form is sent to the Finance Office.
8. The Director of Finance's (DOF) secretary sends the form for fund availability verification.
9. Subject to fund availability, the University Registrar (UR) reviews and approves the form.
10. The form progresses to the Vice Chancellor for final approval.
11. The DOF provides the concluding approval.
12. The Voucher Office then prepares the voucher based on the approved form.
13. The Financial Accountant finalizes the voucher approvals.
14. Funds are transferred to the part-time staff member's account as specified.
15. For inquiries about the request's status, contact the secretary for Optometry or the DOF's secretary.

2.20 Procedure 20 Request for Sabbatical Leave

1. Obtain the sabbatical leave application form from the departmental secretary.
2. Fill in your details as the requesting officer and sign the form.
3. Clearly state the intended start date and duration of the leave.
4. Submit the signed form to the departmental secretary for the HOD's approval.
5. The HOD reviews and signs the form, with possible clarifications if needed.
6. The form is then sent to the Faculty Office for the Dean's signature.
7. The Human Resource Office forwards the form to the Senior Academic Staff Promotion Committee for consideration.
8. The UR and the Vice Chancellor provide the final approval.
9. The HR office communicates the approval and announces the sabbatical leave to the university community.

2.21 Procedure 21: Staff Clearance

1. Request a staff clearance form from the departmental secretary.
2. Complete the form with your name as the requesting officer and sign it.
3. Arrange a meeting with the HOD, presenting inventory committee records.

4. The HOD reviews the form and signs it if there are no issues.
5. The completed form is then circulated to relevant university departments for clearance.
6. The Human Resource Office forwards the cleared form to the DOF.
7. The UR reviews the form for final processing.
8. The HR office confirms the clearance status in writing.

3.0 Pre-semester activities

1. **Course Allocation: Prepare** the course allocation document using the departmental template one month before the new semester begins. Requests to teach new courses should be submitted to the Head of Department (HOD) two weeks prior to this preparation.
2. **Clinical Strengthening:** Conduct clinical strengthening sessions at the beginning of each semester.
3. **Announcing Student Clinical Placement with Hospitals:** Draft and send memos regarding student clinical placements to hospitals one month before the placements commence.
4. **Essilor Scholarship Students:** Send a memo to the finance department two weeks after the students return from holidays. This allows the HOD to verify if students have met the scholarship criteria.
5. **Medic to Medic Scholarship Students:** Coordination for fund requests is managed by Medic to Medic. School fees payments are made in March, and allowances are disbursed in July.
6. **Request for Service Courses:** The HOD should send these requests a month before the semester resumes. Follow-up meetings with the respective department HODs may be necessary.
7. **Adjunct Faculty Requests:** These requests are sent from the HOD to the Human Resources office through the Dean, using the approved template, one month before the semester begins.
8. **Request from Stores:** The requisition book filled out by the secretary needs to be presented to the HOD for signature. After approval, the book is taken to the stores for item collection. The collected items are logged by the inventory committee.
9. **Departmental Meetings:** Schedule these meetings, including exam question moderation and results moderation meetings, at the beginning and end of each semester. They can be conducted face-to-face or virtually. Emergency meetings may be convened as needed to address urgent issues.
10. **Meeting with Students:** Organize meetings with students, led by the HOD and staff members, at the start and end of each semester. These meetings, which can be held face-to-face or virtually, provide an opportunity to discuss key departmental issues and updates. Coordination for these meetings is through the MUOSA and their patron.

11. **Exam Moderation Meeting:** Coordinated by the exam coordinator, this meeting involves reviewing end-of-semester exam questions. Staff members submit their questions three weeks prior to grace week, and these are sent to the external examiner two weeks before. Following the moderation meeting and external examiner comments, staff are expected to make the necessary changes. The exam coordinator ensures that the final exam papers are error-free and do not contain answers before printing.

4.0 Post semester activities

Results Moderation:

- Faculty members are expected to commence marking immediately after the completion of examinations.
- Once graded, the compiled results for each course should be sent to the departmental secretary, with a copy to the Head of Department (HOD).
- The secretary will compile the end-of-semester results using the specified template.
- The results coordinator, in consultation with the HOD, will schedule a results moderation meeting.
- Post-meeting, the results are submitted to the Faculty for further recommendation to the senate.
- Once approved by the senate, the results are published on the university portal, accessible only to students.

Departmental Meetings:

- Monthly departmental meetings are held, especially before the commencement and at the closure of each semester.
- Notices for these meetings should be issued at least one week in advance.
- The meeting agenda and supporting documents are to be shared with the staff at least three days prior to the meeting.

2. Training and Workshops:

- Continuing Professional Development (CPD) sessions are organized monthly, in collaboration with the eye department at AVC MCH.
- Additionally, at least one training session or workshop is arranged during the holiday period following the marking phase.
- Staff members are encouraged to propose training areas and nominate facilitators, coordinated through the HOD's office.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this manual serves as a vital tool in maintaining the operational excellence of the Optometry Department at Mzuzu University. It is designed not only as a reference for daily tasks

but also as a framework for sustaining the high-quality standards that our department is known for. By following the guidelines and procedures outlined herein, our staff can contribute significantly to the academic and professional development of our students, ensuring that they are well-prepared to excel in the dynamic and evolving field of optometry.

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